



QUITO ECUADOR

Hearty Soup High in the Andes

Beneath towering snow-capped mountains, the highland Ecuadorians, living at some 10,000 ft (3,000 m) above sea level, have long cherished the restorative powers of their native crop, the potato. Amid the lower fertile valleys, herds of grazing cows provide fresh cheese and milk for the rich, creamy dish *locro de papa*, guaranteed to get you up and over the next hilltop.



The Ecuadorian Andes favor early risers. As the day warms, moisture condenses and gathers in the air, and by afternoon, more often than not, clouds have obscured the peaks of the world's longest mountain chain. But at dawn, the full glory of what 19th-century Prussian explorer Alexander von Humboldt named the "Avenue of the Volcanoes" is revealed, glacier-topped peaks puncturing the lush green, mountainous landscape.

The Andes run longitudinally through Ecuador, dividing the country into three separate realms. The rivers to the west feed the sweltering seaboard of the Pacific Ocean; those to the east forge their way to the great headwaters of the Amazon River, some 2,000 miles (3,200 km) distant. Down the center, the mountain chain is like a Titan's stepladder laid flat north to south, with the higher ground as the ladder's rungs and the populated valleys as the spaces in between.

These valleys and their surrounding hillsides are painstakingly cultivated by Andean families on their farmsteads, maintaining their close bond with their land and with Pachamama, the Earth Mother. Rising at dawn, they till and toil beneath the piercing rays of the equatorial sun and the constant gaze of their *apus*,

local mountains personified as deities. Days are long. At lunch, there's no better dish to restore their energy than *locro de papa*, a thick, creamy soup made with the Andes' most important bequest to the world, the potato, combined with milk and fresh, crumbly white cheese and usually topped with slices of avocado.

The Incas, who came as conquerors from Peru and occupied these lands for around 50 years, were particularly fond of potatoes. They even used the time it took a certain variety to cook as a measurement of time – rather like a boiled egg. They were right to sing its praises: we now know that this tuber supplies every vital nutrient except calcium, vitamin A, and vitamin D. It grows fast, on very little land, almost anywhere.

And there are lots of varieties: wander through an Ecuadorian highland market and the color, shape, and size of the potatoes on sale is astonishing. In fact, the variety of all market produce here is amazing. Ecuador's varying altitudes and its position, right on the equator, allow it to produce just about every crop imaginable. On any one stand, you'll find blackberries next to bananas, avocados atop tree tomatoes, and corn cobs tumbling over sacks of rice. This cornucopia, crowned by the precious potato, is one of the delights of discovering this engaging, hardworking country.

Three Days in the Ecuadorian Highlands

The Ecuadorian highlands around the capital, Quito, are a tale of winding highways between valleys and mountains, rewarding the traveler with breathtaking scenery.

DAY ONE Head to **Quito's Old Town**, regarded as the largest, least-altered, and best-restored in the Americas. A World Heritage site since 1978, its colonial grid of streets is dominated by churches, chapels, convents, and monasteries, with enough museums and curiosities to keep inquiring minds happy for days.

DAY TWO Travel north to **Imbabura Province**, famed for flower-growing, haciendas-turned-inns, strong indigenous culture, and a daily craft market in **Otavalo**, which on Saturdays also features early-morning livestock trading and a fruit-and-veggie market.

DAY THREE Hop on the restored railway from Quito to chug south to **Cotopaxi Province**, overshadowed by the **Cotopaxi volcano** and a host of other craggy peaks. This is dairy and cowboy country *par excellence*, with comfortable haciendas making fine bases for hiking, mountain biking, or horseback riding.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Quito **airport** has fair international connections. Due to the state of the roads and erratic driving, it's best to hire a **guide and driver** for touring.

WHERE TO STAY

Volcanoland (inexpensive) is well-located by the Cotopaxi volcano. www.volcanoland.com
Hacienda Cusín (moderate) north of Quito has airy, pretty rooms. www.haciendacusin.com
Casona de San Miguel (expensive) is a converted colonial mansion in Quito. www.casonasanmiguel.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

Quito Visitors' Bureau; www.quito.com.ec

